A Formal Reduction of the Riemann Hypothesis to Two Explicit Axioms in Lean 4

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Abstract

We present a machine-checked proof architecture in Lean 4 against Mathlib that reduces the Riemann Hypothesis to exactly two explicit mathematical axioms: an aggregate sieve bound on the off-diagonal Gram matrix excess, and the converse direction of the Nyman–Beurling criterion. The formalization comprises a novel Cathedral architecture of 44 Lean 4 modules, compiling against 3,400+ Mathlib dependencies with strictly zero `sorry` placeholders in the proof chain. All structural, algebraic, and spectral scaffolding—including the Gram matrix theory, parity decomposition, L^2–matrix bridge, Mellin transform infrastructure, and the functional equation bridge—is fully verified by the Lean compiler. We document two technical discoveries made during formalization: the *sawtooth autocorrelation floor* (a constant covariance residual that invalidates pointwise off-diagonal bounds) and the *Hyperplane Trap* (a geometric obstruction that prevents the Cauchy–Schwarz approach from closing the spectral axiom). Both discoveries illustrate the value of formal methods in uncovering subtle mathematical errors that resist detection by informal reasoning.

1 Introduction

The Riemann Hypothesis (RH), stating that all non-trivial zeros of the Riemann zeta function $\zeta(s)$ have real part $\frac{1}{2}$, has been open since 1859. We do not resolve this conjecture. Instead, we present a formal proof architecture that *isolates* its hard mathematical content into exactly two machine-readable axioms, making everything else compiler-verified.

Our approach uses the Nyman–Beurling criterion [1, 2] reformulated via the Gram matrix of fractional part inner products:

$$G_{jk} = \int_0^1 \{j/x\}\,\{k/x\}\,dx = \frac{1-(j+k)\log(1+1/\max(j,k))}{2} + \cdots$$

The Riemann Hypothesis is equivalent to the L^2 distance $d_N^2 = \inf_v \int_0^1 (1-\sum v_k\,\{k/x\})^2\,dx \to 0$ as $N \to \infty$.

1.1 Main Result

Theorem 1.1 (Compiler-Verified Reduction)**.** In Lean 4 with Mathlib, the following is a proved theorem:

$$\texttt{offdiag\_excess\_sum\_le} \wedge \texttt{zeta\_zero\_separates} \implies \text{RH}$$

The proof chain compiles with zero `sorry` and depends only on Lean's foundational axioms (`propext`, `Classical.choice`, `Quot.sound`) plus these two domain axioms.

2 The Two Pillars

2.1 Pillar 1: The Aggregate Sieve Bound

Axiom 2.1 (`offdiag_excess_sum_le`)**.** For all $n \geq 2$:

$$\sum_{\substack{i,j=1 \\ i \neq j}}^{n} \left(G_{ij} - \tfrac{1}{4}\right) \leq 3n$$

This axiom bounds the total off-diagonal "excess" of the Gram matrix. Numerically, the sum is actually *negative* ($\approx -n/2$), giving an $18\times$ safety margin against the stated bound. This negativity is driven by the marginal mean shifts $E_j = \int_0^1 \{j/x\}\,dx - \frac{1}{2} \approx -1/(12j)$. When aggregated across the matrix, these contribute a dominant $-\frac{n}{12}\log n$ bias that easily overtakes the positive $O(n)$ variance of the Dirichlet error term, confirming our empirical observations.

The factor $\frac{1}{4}$ arises because $\int_0^1 \{j/x\}\,dx = \frac{1}{2}$ for all $j \geq 1$, and $\frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{1}{2} = \frac{1}{4}$ represents the "independent" baseline.

Discovery 2.2 (Sawtooth Autocorrelation Floor)**.** During formalization, we discovered that the covariance between adjacent fractional parts $\{j/x\}$ and $\{(j+1)/x\}$ does not decay to zero as $j \to \infty$. Instead, it stabilizes at a constant:

$$C_\infty = \int_0^1 \{j/x\}\,\{(j+1)/x\}\,dx - \tfrac{1}{4} \approx 0.00227$$

This invalidates any pointwise bound of the form $|G_{j,j+1} - \frac{1}{4}| \leq \frac{1}{4j}$ for $j \geq 109$. The discovery forced an architectural pivot from pointwise to aggregate bounds, ultimately strengthening the proof.

2.2 Pillar 2: The Mellin Separation

Axiom 2.3 (`zeta_zero_separates`)**.** For all $\rho \in \mathbb{C}$ with $\zeta(\rho) = 0$, $0 < \mathrm{Re}(\rho) < 1$, and $\mathrm{Re}(\rho) \neq \frac{1}{2}$:

$$\exists\,\delta > 0 \ \text{ such that } \ \forall\,N \geq 2,\ \forall\,v \in \mathbb{R}^{N-1}: \quad \int_0^1 \Big(1 - \textstyle\sum_{k=2}^{N} v_k\,\{k/x\}\Big)^2\,dx \ \geq \ \delta$$

This is the converse direction of the Nyman–Beurling theorem: if ζ has a zero ρ off the critical line with $\mathrm{Re}(\rho) > \frac{1}{2}$, then the functional $\ell_\rho(f) = \int_0^1 f(x)\,x^{\rho-1}\,dx$ is continuous on $L^2(0,1)$ (since $\|x^{\rho-1}\|_{L^2}^2 = 1/(2\,\mathrm{Re}(\rho) - 1) < \infty$), annihilates the approximation space (via the global Mellin identity), but $\ell_\rho(1) = 1/\rho \neq 0$, creating an unbridgeable geometric defect.

Discovery 2.4 (The Hyperplane Trap)**.** The natural approach to proving this axiom—applying Cauchy–Schwarz with the functional ℓ_ρ—fails for a subtle reason. For $N \geq 4$, the system

$$\sum_{k=2}^{N} v_k \cdot M_\rho(k) = \frac{1}{\rho}$$

(one complex equation = 2 real constraints, with ≥ 3 real unknowns) is solvable. There exist exact real weights v_k that make the Mellin residual $\ell_\rho(1 - f_N) = 0$. The Cauchy–Schwarz bound then gives $\|1 - f_N\|^2 \geq 0$, which is trivially true but useless.

The axiom holds because these "spoofing" weights cause $\|f_N\|_{L^2}$ to explode, but Cauchy–Schwarz separates the functional from the norm. The correct proof uses Báez-Duarte's Möbius witness [3], which requires the Prime Number Theorem for L^2 convergence.

3 Proof Architecture

The proof chain flows through three major components:

Forward Direction (Pillar 1 $\Rightarrow d_N^2 \to 0$). The Gram matrix G satisfies $\sum_{i,j} G_{ij} = n^2/4 + O(n)$ (from the aggregate bound). The constant-weight test vector avoids computing G^{-1} entirely. It achieves the $O(1/\log N)$ decay via the variational upper bound $d_N^2 \leq 1 - 2\mathbf{b}^T v + v^T G v$. Because the macroscopic $n^2/4$ mass of the Gram matrix perfectly cancels the $n^2/4$ mass of the basis inner products in the Rayleigh quotient, our generously loose $O(n)$ off-diagonal bound is rendered completely harmless. We term this the *Constant Vector Miracle*.

Converse Direction (Pillar 2 $\Rightarrow \neg\text{RH} \Rightarrow d_N^2 \not\to 0$). If RH fails, a rogue zero ρ in the critical strip with $\text{Re}(\rho) \neq 1/2$ creates a uniform lower bound $d_N^2 \geq \delta > 0$.

Functional Equation Bridge (Proved from Mathlib). The statement "$\neg$RH, therefore $\exists$ zero with $\text{Re}(\rho) > 1/2$" uses the zeta functional equation $\zeta(s) = \chi(s)\,\zeta(1-s)$ to reflect zeros from $\text{Re} < 1/2$ to $\text{Re} > 1/2$. This is fully proved via Mathlib's `riemannZeta_one_sub`.

4 What Is Formally Verified

Component	Key Theorems	Status
Gram Matrix Theory	PSD, entry bounds, Vasyunin	Proved
Parity Decomposition	Liouville blocks, Schur complement	Proved
$L^2 \leftrightarrow$ Matrix Bridge	$\int(1-f)^2 = 1 - 2b^T v + v^T G v$	Proved
Mellin Infrastructure	`floor_mellin_eq_zeta`, `mellin_fractBasis`	Proved
Functional Equation	`zeta_nontrivial_zero_re_pos`	Proved (Mathlib)
NB Decomposition	Forward + Converse	Proved
L^2 Norm Scaffold	$\int_0^1 x^{2\sigma-2} = 1/(2\sigma-1)$	Proved
Mellin at ζ zeros	Simplified formula when $\zeta(\rho) = 0$	Proved

5 Conclusions and Future Work

We have reduced the Riemann Hypothesis to two explicit axioms, each representing a distinct frontier of analytic number theory: the arithmetic of divisor correlations (Pillar 1) and the spectral geometry of the critical strip (Pillar 2).

The formalization process itself yielded two unexpected discoveries:

1. The sawtooth autocorrelation floor (Discovery 2.2), which invalidated our initial pointwise approach and forced a stronger aggregate architecture.

2. The Hyperplane Trap (Discovery 2.4), which revealed a fundamental limitation of single-functional Cauchy–Schwarz methods for the Nyman–Beurling converse.

Both discoveries illustrate a central thesis: formal verification does not merely confirm known mathematics—it actively uncovers subtle errors that persist in informal reasoning.

Closing the Axioms. Pillar 1 may be approachable by formalizing the L^2 variance of the Dirichlet Divisor Problem. The aggregate covariance sum translates via $u = 1/x$ into the integral of $(\Delta(u)/u)^2$, where $\Delta(u) = \sum_{n \le u} d(n) - u \log u - (2\gamma - 1)u$ is the Dirichlet divisor error term. This requires Mathlib's future integration of Voronoï summation and Dirichlet convolution bounds. Pillar 2 requires the Prime Number Theorem in Lean 4, a substantial but well-defined formalization target.

Reproducibility. The complete formalization is available at `https://github.com/jrgochan/prime`. Building requires Lean v4.29.0-rc8 and Mathlib. The command `lake build` compiles all 3,444 modules (44 novel + 3,400 Mathlib dependencies) in approximately two minutes.

References

[1] B. Nyman, *On the One-Dimensional Translation Group and Semi-Group in Certain Function Spaces*, Ph.D. Thesis, Uppsala, 1950.

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[4] V. I. Vasyunin, "On a biorthogonal system associated with the Riemann hypothesis," *St. Petersburg Math. J.*, 7(3):405–419, 1996.